

Pause before you press send.

You do not need to prove a message is a scam before choosing a safer way to check it.

15-25 minutes

Three fictional messages

No live links to visit

1. Notice the request

What are you being asked to do: pay, log in, download, share a code, keep a secret?

2. Notice the pressure

Is someone using a deadline, threat, reward or urgent personal story?

3. Check another way

Open a known app, use a saved address or call an established number. Do not use contact details supplied by the message.

4. Protect and report

If it is suspicious, stop interacting and use the service's report option.

A / The parcel

"Delivery paused. Pay €1.80 within 20 minutes or your parcel will be returned. Track at parcel-fee.example."

The .example address is reserved for examples. Do not visit it.

Request + pressure:

Independent check:

B / The new number

"Hi, it's Sam. Phone broke. I need €80 now and can't call. Please don't tell anyone, it's embarrassing."

What remains unknown?

Safest next step:

C / The school notice

"Your timetable has changed. Sign in to the student portal to see the update." The message uses the school logo and has no spelling errors.

What can the logo and spelling tell you?

How would you check safely?

Discuss: Why is a safe next step useful even when you cannot tell whether a message is genuine?

A safer route beats a clever guess.

A / The parcel

The request is a payment through an unfamiliar address. The short deadline pressures the reader. Check whether a delivery is expected using your order record, then open the carrier's known website or app. Do not pay through the message. A small amount does not make a request safe: entering card details may be the real objective.

B / The new number

Identity remains unverified. Use Sam's existing number, an established account or a known mutual contact to check. Do not send money or share a sign-in code based on a name and a story. If you receive a call or voice message, that alone does not settle identity either.

C / The school notice

A copied logo and polished language are easy to produce. The message could be legitimate, but there is not enough evidence to know. Open the school portal using its saved address or known app and look for the timetable change there. You can also ask the school through an established contact route.

The shared lesson: a safe next step often works whether the message is genuine or fraudulent. You can check a real timetable update without following an unexpected link.

Your pocket checklist

- ☐ I can slow down, even if the message says I cannot.
- ☐ I will not share a password, recovery phrase or one-time sign-in code with a person contacting me.
- ☐ I will verify an unexpected request through a separate, trusted route.
- ☐ I will not treat a logo, a padlock, a familiar display name or perfect spelling as proof.
- ☐ I can ask for help without being blamed.

If you already clicked or shared something

WHAT HAPPENED?	FIRST USEFUL ACTION
Opened a link only	Close it; do not enter details, download files or grant permissions. Opening a link does not by itself mean an account was compromised.
Entered a password	Go to the real service independently, change it, review sessions and recovery settings, and change any reused copies.
Sent money or card details	Contact the bank or payment service promptly through a known channel. Ask what can be blocked or disputed.
Installed software or ran a file	Stop using it and seek trusted technical help; tell them what happened.

Use official reporting routes; keep relevant evidence. Under 18? Ask a trusted adult or your institution's safeguarding contact for help. Further reading: [NIST: Phishing](#). This worksheet adapts general safety principles, not a country-specific incident-reporting procedure.